

Trimorphic Protennoia

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by John D. Turner

Trimorphic Protennoia ("The Three-formed [Divine] First Thought") is, in its form, a Barbeloite treatise which has undergone both Sethian and Christian revisions. It is roughly contemporaneous with *The Apocryphon of John* (mid-second century C.E.), which it resembles in certain interesting ways, and is distinguished by a number of striking parallels to the Fourth Gospel and especially its prologue.

The underlying basis of *Trimorphic Protennoia* can be seen in the series consistent "I am" self-predicatory aretalogies, in which Protennoia recites her divine identity and role in the creation and salvation of the world. These are structured into an introductory aretalogy (35,1-32) identifying Protennoia as the divine First Thought followed by three similar aretalogies in the same style, the second and third of which form separately titled subtractates in the *Trimorphic Protennoia*: First, Protennoia is the Voice of the First Thought who descends first as light into darkness to give shape to her fallen members (35,32-36,27; 40,29-41,1). Second, Protennoia is the Speech of the Thought who descends to empower her fallen members by giving them spirit or breath (42,4-27; 45,2-12; 45,21-46,3). Third, Protennoia is the Word or Logos of the Thought who descends in the likeness of the powers, assumes a human appearance, introduces the illuminatory baptismal rite of the Five Seals and restores her members into the light (46,5-6; 47,5-22; 49,15-22; 50,9-12,18-20).

One cannot fail to notice here a striking resemblance, not only to the language and structure of the Johannine prologue's narration of the descents of the Logos, but also to the similar first-person aretalogy on the three descents of Pronoia found at the end of the longer version of the *Apocryphon of John* (11,7:30,11-31,25), with which the *Trimorphic Protennoia* may even be genetically related.

The underlying tripartite aretalogy has been expanded by means of six narrative doctrinal insertions (36,27-40,29; 41,1-42,2; 42,27-45,2; 46,7-47,5; 47,22-49,15; 49,22-50,9). Three of these insertions, whose third-person expository prose breaks the otherwise smooth flow of Protennoia's self-referential speech, are designated as "mysteries" which Protennoia is said to have communicated to the sons of the light.

Essentially, the scheme of the divine First Thought's triple descent into this world is a derivative of speculation at home in the Hellenistic Jewish wisdom schools responsible for the personification of the figure of the divine wisdom and the development of the myth concerning her role in the creation of the world and in the subsequent enlightenment of mankind as it is found especially in 1 Enoch 42, Sirach 24, Wisdom 7-8, and in Philo. It seems that Sophia's two unsuccessful descents in 1 Enoch 42 and her successful one in Sirach 24 were combined into a total of

three descents into the lower world, two resulting in partial liberation, and the third resulting in the final awakening and salvation of those who received her. This is the same pattern that underlies the Johannine prologue, which, though not a Barbeloite composition, was likely also a product of a similar form of wisdom speculation. The unique contribution of the Barbeloites seems to have been the interpretation of the three revelatory descents: first, in terms of a primal divine triad of Father, Mother and Son, second in terms of a theory of progressive revelation in which each successive appearance of the revealer is characterized by an increasing degree of articulateness and finality (Voice, Speech, and Word) and third, the association of the final descent with a Logos figure who confers final enlightenment in the form of transcendentalized baptismal rite called the Five Seals.

It is clear that the *Trimorphic Protennoia* has been secondarily Christianized. Three glosses identifying the Autogenes Son as the Christ in the first subtractate (37,[31]; 38,22; 39,6-7) probably derive from the traditional Barbeloite theogonical material common to *The Apocryphon of John* and Irenaeus, *Haer.* 1.29, upon which the author drew for the first narrative insertion. These Christian glosses would have been suggested by an equation between the Christian designation of Christ as *monogenes* and what seems to be a pre-Christian designation for the third member of the Barbeloite Father-Mother-Son triad, namely the Self-Begotten (*autogenes*) Son.

The third subtractate narrates the incognito descent of Protennoia as the Word disguised in the form of the sovereignties, powers, and angels, culminating in the final revelation of herself in the human form of her members below, but it seems to have been supplemented by an alien and tendentious Christological interpretation. In the third subtractate, traditional Christological titles such as Christ, Beloved, Son of God (i.e., “Son of the Archigenetor”) and Son of Man are polemically interpreted in a consciously docetic fashion so as to suggest that these titles were inappropriately applied to the human Jesus by the apostolic church. By implication, the apostolic Jesus is shown actually to be the Christ of the evil archons; the apostolic beloved is actually the Beloved of the archons; the apostolic Son of God is the Son of the ignorant world creator; and the apostolic Son of Man is only a human being among the sons of men.

It is interesting that most of these reinterpretations of the Christology of the apostolic church in the *Trimorphic Protennoia* seem to depend on key passages from the Gospel of John to score their point in any acute fashion. It seems that the key to the relationship between these two texts lies in the recognition that *Trimorphic Protennoia* has undergone at least three stages of composition. First, there was the original triad of the aretalogical self-predications of Protennoia as Voice, Speech, and Word that were probably built up out of the Jewish wisdom tradition and maybe out of *The Apocryphon of John*’s similar Pronoia aretalogy itself sometime during the first century C.E.; there is little here that seems specifically gnostic or Christian or Sethian or Barbeloite. Second, this was supplemented, whether by the same or by a different author, by various narrative doctrinal passages based upon traditional Barbeloite theogonical materials similar to those of *The Apocryphon of John* and Irenaeus, *Haer.* 1.29. After circulation as a mildly Christian Barbeloite text in this form, the third and last stage of composition seems to have involved a deliberately polemical incorporation of Christian, specifically Johannine Christian, materials into the aretalogical portion of the third subtractate. One might assign the third compositional stage of *Trimorphic Protennoia* to the period of struggle over the interpretation of the

Christology of the Fourth Gospel witnessed by the New Testament letters of John, perhaps the first quarter or half of the second century.